I Can Hear My Soul Cracking

By Slavenka Drakulic

MOTHER: **(Pg 51+)** You ask me about my son? How I felt when I saw Azmir being killed? My child, how can I answer that kind of question? How can I tell you that? What words can I use to describe my pain? You say "killed," and it seems to me that you feel nothing—how could you? He is only a name to you. But my whole body trembles when I hear it, just that one word. Azmir, my son, he was the soul of my soul. . .

But perhaps I should try to tell you that, for the sake of others who show remorse and have respect for my tragedy. And for the sake of other mothers like me, I know that they are many.

INTRODUCTION

In 1995, a paramilitary Serbian unit known as the Scorpions executed six unidentified civilian men. Four of them were underage; the other two, under 30. The soldiers filmed the executions to be used for educational purposes. A "how to" instructional video for executions, if you will.

Before the film footage was destroyed, a US film company created a documentary covering the Bosnian War. And the events of Srebrenica. More than 8,000 men and boys in and around the town of Srebrenica were killed – a massacre – a genocide.

Fast forward to 2005. Imagine flipping through the channels on your television only to come across film footage of your son's execution. A son who had disappeared a decade earlier when he was only 16.

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MOTHER: That day it was only the beginning of June but already very hot. Just like that July day in Srebrenica ten years ago, I thought as I put a dzezva with water for a coffee on a stove. My second coffee of the day. It was late afternoon, and soon my neighbor Amra will come home from work with her young daughter, Selma. Often I envied her for having a daughter; it is such a blessing to have a female child in a time of war. But I am wrong, of course. A woman's curse is different, that's all. I was grateful that Amra was helping me. I expected that the three of us would have a supper together and watch television, as we did

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every evening. Ten years passed. If Azmir had not disappeared, he would have been twenty-six now—a grown-up man, maybe even married. I still remember that he liked that dark-haired girl from his school class, though nowadays it would be difficult for them to marry.

She was a Serb. I like to imagine what would happen if he were here with me. I daydream about his job—he was so good with his hands—and a new house that he would surely be able to build. I like to daydream, imagining Azmir had the power to warm me and wake me up from a cold that I felt inside. That warmth used to keep me alive. But then immediately, I feel shame, the same feeling that I have experienced so many times, shame that I am alive and he. . . . Why? Why me? If someone had asked me to trade my life for that of my son, Azmir, I gladly would have done it. Not very tall and rather thin, he looked younger than his age—no more than a boy, really! This was the reason that I believed Azmir could be spared by soldiers. How wrong I was, I thought, embittered, sitting in the kitchen that afternoon. I slowly sipped my thick, strong coffee. See, I was convinced that I was reconciled with Azmir's death long ago. Only I didn't mention that ugly word, not even to myself. What else would keep him from coming back to me, calling me, for ten years? No way Azmir would not contact me somehow, through relatives, perhaps, he would find a way. My whole body told me that Azmir was no longer in this world, the same as his uncle, who was killed by Arkan's soldiers when he visited Bijeljina at the very beginning of the war. At least I knew about him, I was certain, I was even able to get his body (for money, of course) and bury him properly. It is important to give people a burial; one should not be buried without a name, together with others in a mass grave. Why do we all have a name? We have it in life, and we should have it in death, that's what I think. And I wanted to bury Azmir properly, if he was . . . Well. Although I felt Azmir's end in my every muscle and bone, the truth is that I did not know for certain what had happened to him. And when. And where. It was not officially confirmed, or so I was told. In the last few years there were bones dug out, bones of thousands of men who were executed around Srebrenica.

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Like other women, I went to identify remnants of my son. But a watch and a few photos and a piece of shirt I was shown, together with some darkened bones, were not his—odd how thin and fragile human bones look, as if eaten by earth, I thought. I remember letting out a big sigh, not knowing if I was relieved that these remains were not Azmir's, or unhappy that I could not finally get over with the torture of living with uncertainty year after year. Thinking that his bones are shattered in the woods, that he is not buried, that some other mother—just like me—looks at someone's things with fear and then relief. I was afraid that Azmir was not only dead but also lost for me, lost forever. So, that evening I was in the kitchen washing dishes after dinner with Amra and Selma, as usual. Just then I heard a voice from the TV in the living room saying something about Srebrenica. Ah, yet another program, I thought. I had seen a few in the years that passed, always with a knot in my throat while looking for the familiar face of Azmir and hoping that I wouldn't see it. I was tired of this, not sure that I could force myself to watch anything that had to do with Srebrenica again. Ten years is a long time when you wait. Why look at that program, what could it tell me that I already didn't know?

Yet I could not resist and went back to the living room and sat down. Amra was still there; Selma had gone back to their apartment. It was not a real film but some kind of a documentary, they said, and the picture was shaking, jumping. But I could see the Serbian soldiers in fatigue uniforms and red caps, their faces in front of the camera.

They were not even hiding, so sure they were of themselves, so arrogant. . . . And then I saw a group of four prisoners, young men with their hands tied in the back. The soldiers killed them just like that. It all happened so abruptly, so quickly, that I had no time to react, to switch off the TV set or something. But when another two prisoners appeared on the screen, I averted my eyes. I was not quick enough, though . . . because from the corner of my eye, I saw a familiar figure.

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Instantly, I recognized my son, Azmir, his light brown hair, his hands, his shirt. He stood there for a short while with his hands tied back, bent slightly forward. Suddenly, I felt pressure in my chest, as if I were sinking into water—like when I was small and fell into a river. I gasped for air, but there was not enough. I could hear no sound, not even my heartbeat, nor could I utter a single sound. I was trapped in that water. In that room, in that picture on the screen, and there was no way out. I knew what was coming. When Azmir turned toward the camera with a frown on his forehead so familiar to me—because he used to frown like that when he was small and frightened, just before he would start crying—I tried to close my eyes. I had seen enough. But my own eyes betrayed me, and I stared while Azmir took a bullet and fell gently on his back. Now it all happened very, very slowly, or it only seemed so to me, I didn't know any longer, nor did I care. I was still under the water with my lungs about to explode. Then I felt Amra shaking me gently, and I took a breath. I saw what I had seen so many times in my nightmares—but now, for the first time, I saw it to the very end. In my nightmare, there was never an end, and I would wake up wishing to know . . . the end. That evening I saw it. I know it now.

When I finally managed to close my eyes, I heard a strange sound coming from somewhere inside me. The sound of cracking, like cracking of ice in the springtime. "I can hear my soul cracking," I said to Amra. She held me tightly in her arms for a while. That night, alone in my bed, I saw the same picture again and again. Not of Azmir's death, but of his face, looking for help that did not come.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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